

The Official opening of the Muslim Student Centre and Hostel

The Muslim Student Centre and Hostel was officially opened on Friday, 3rd November, 1972. The opening ceremony which began at 7.15 p.m. was attended by about fifty distinguished guests which included diplomats from Muslim countries and British and Muslim press.

The setting up of this Centre and Hostel came as a result of the acute need felt by Muslim students in this country. In 1965, The FOSIS at its 2nd Annual Conference held at Manchester passed a resolution to study the possibility of setting up a center and hostel in London to cater for the needs of Muslim students. The Federation then went on to set up the Muslim Student Trust to implement the resolution.

A fund raising campaign was immediately launched and a boost was given to the fund by His Majesty King Feisal who, during his official visit to Britain in May 1967, gave a generous donation of £20,000.

In 1970, after a long search, the present building was purchased. While the conversion work was in progress, the Trust was very short of funds. An appeal for funds was well responded by the Muslim students and some members of the Muslim public who advanced interest-free loans and donations amounting to well over £7,000.

The Centre and Hostel was completed in April 1972 and from then onwards started taking in residents, receiving and entertaining guests and housing the offices of the Trust, FOSIS and THE MUSLIM.

Among the activities which have taken place at the Centre since April 1972 were wedding receptions, conversion ceremonies, dinner-receptions and film shows to newly-arrived Muslim students, Iftar receptions during Ramadan and tea parties for distinguished Muslims visiting Britain. Some of the guests that the Centre has had so far included Prof. Naggar of the University of Kuwait, Sheikh Yusef Hamid al-Nil of the Ministry of Awqaf, Sudan, Prof. Irving of the University of Tennessee, U.S.A., Prof. Syed A. Ashraf of the University of Karachi, His Excellency Hussain Siraj, the Director of Rabitah (World Muslim League) and Mr. Ali Abdullah of the Islamic Secretariat, Jeddah.

Mr. Salim Azzam, Minister at the Saudi Arabian Embassy stressed that Islam is a religion of unity and justice and expressed his confidence that, by the Grace of ALLAH, the Centre would be able to promote these qualities. He also hoped that the Trust would set up more Muslim student centres all over Britain. He then announced that he had with him a £11,000.00 donation from His Majesty King Feisal. To mark the official opening of the Centre he called upon Br. Mohamed Salleh Akram to call the Adhan.

After that, several other distinguished guests were requested to give a short address to the gathering. His Excellency Kemal Rifaat, the Ambassador of Egypt, hoped that the Centre would contribute to the unity of Muslims not only among students in Britain but also among non-students all over the world.

The Deputy High Commissioner for Kenya, Mr. A. O. Fakhri, expressed his admiration for the "splendid achievement" which happened "without our being aware of it". He promised his full support and co-operation for the Centre but regretted that, since his country is comparatively poor he could not promise financial support. Another guest who spoke was Mr. Abdulaziz al-Turki, the Cultural Counsellor at the Saudi Arabian embassy. He informed the gathering that His Majesty King Feisal was taking a great interest in the project and had instructed him "to follow up the contributions that His Majesty's government has made and to keep in touch with the activities and developments of the Centre". His Excellency the Raja of Mahmudabad, the Director of the Islamic Cultural Centre, congratulated the Trust for the achievement and expressed his confidence that, with this quality of Muslim youths, the future of Islam is very bright indeed.

The guests were then invited into the dining hall where snacks were served. They were also shown round the buildings and, at the FOSIS office, were informed about FOSIS and its activities.

The Centre provides accommodation for twelve residents and a warden. The residential accommodation is on the first floor, having an area of about 1,400 sq. ft. On the ground floor are the Library, Lounge, Prayer Room, Kitchen, Dining Hall and Laundrette contained in the same floor area. Except for the kitchen, all the areas in the ground floor are open to the Muslim students. In the basement are the offices of the Trust, FOSIS and the MUSLIM, with stores, contained in an area of 250 sq. ft. The whole building is heated by a gas-fired central heating system. The front garden of the building has been landscaped and paved to provide a parking space for three cars. The rear garden is planted with lawn and terrace.

The cost of acquisition, building repairs and conversion, etc., is about £37,000. The cost of furnishing the Centre is about £4,000. It is hoped, as and when finance becomes available, to provide further residential accommodation by the conversion of the roof space.

The Centre is being run by the Trust whose Secretary is also presently in charge of it. We pray to Allah for His past blessings and hope that in future, by His Grace, the Centre will contribute more to Islam.